

HostBooks Customer Engagement Methodology (HCEM)

End-to-End Framework for Winning, Delivering and Expanding with Customers

Customer & Opportunity Summary



Customer Summary: (Brief description of the customer's business, industry, size, locations)



Link to Opportunity: (Link to CRM opportunity)



Opportunity Summary: (Solutions in scope – ERP, Accounting, Tax, Payroll, Compliance, Integrations)



Partner Name: (Name of Partner / Channel)



Value Hypothesis: (Why Change, Why Now, Why HostBooks?)



Engagement Model: (Implementation / Advisory / Managed Services)

Forecast Info



Opportunity Name: _____



Opportunity ID: _____



Est. Close Date: _____



Est. Annual Value (ARR): ₹ _____



Forecast: ☐ Commit ☐ Commit At Risk ☐ Upside ☐ Uncommitted



Stage: ☐ Discover ☐ Diagnose ☐ Design ☐ Propose ☐ Negotiate ☐ Close



Last Updated: _____

Customer Business Goals & Strategies



- Goal / Strategy 1
- Goal / Strategy 2
- Goal / Strategy 3

Customer Business Challenges



- Challenge 1
- Challenge 2
- Challenge 3

Customer KPIs & Expected Returns



- KPI 1 & Target
- KPI 2 & Target
- KPI 3 & Target
- Expected ROI
- Payback Period

Solutions / Capabilities in Scope



- Capability / Module 1
- Capability / Module 2
- Capability / Module 3
- Additional Integrations

Customer Project Risks



- Business Risk 1
- Technical Risk 2
- Adoption Risk 3
- Timeline Risk
- Cost of Doing Nothing?

Engagement Strategy



- Discovery Workshop
- Process Mapping
- Demo / POC
- Business Value Assessment
- Proposal & Commercial

Why HostBooks? (Differentiators)



- Unified ERP + Accounting
- AI Assistant (HB Zeno)
- India Compliance Ready
- Faster Implementation
- Lower TCO
- Strong Partner Ecosystem

Technical Close (Y/N)



Technical Feasibility: _____
Known Blockers / Risks:

- Item 1
- Item 2
- Item 3

Help Required From: _____



Executive Sponsor

Customer Sponsor: _____

Partner Sponsor: _____

HostBooks Sponsor: _____

Executive Ask / Support: _____



Concessions (Give / Get)

Give

- Give 1
- Give 2
- Give 3

Get

- Get 1
- Get 2
- Get 3

Stakeholder Map (Key Decision Makers)

Name / Title	Role on Deal	Influence	Sentiment	HostBooks Contact
Economic Buyer		High	●	
Business Sponsor / Champion		High	●	
Influencer		Medium	●	
IT Decision Maker		Medium	●	
Procurement / Finance		Medium	●	
End User Representative		Low	●	

Sentiment: ● Advocate ● Neutral ● Detractor

Reverse Timeline (Key Actions)

Milestone / Key Action	Owner	Target Date
1. Contract Signature		
2. Commercial Approval		
3. Final Proposal		
4. Technical Validation / POC		
5. Business Case Approval		
6. Executive Review		
7. Discovery Workshop		



Opportunity Account Team

Role	Name
Account Owner	
Solution Consultant	
Presales Consultant	
Implementation Lead	
Customer Success Manager	
Finance / Commercial Lead	



Partner / Influencer

Partner Name: _____

Partner Type: _____

Partner Champion: _____

Partner Engagement Level:

☐ High ☐ Medium ☐ Low

Partner Incentive / Motivation: _____



Forecast Justification

Why is this deal forecasted as selected?

Key Assumptions:

- _____
- _____
- _____



Next 5 Key Actions

Action	Owner	Due Date
1.		
2.		
3.		
4.		
5.		

HCEM Engagement Stages



1 Discover
Understand & Qualify



2 Diagnose
Analyze & Design



3 Design
Solution & Business Case



4 Close
Commit & Contract



5 Adopt & Expand
Deliver Value & Grow

Exit Criteria

- Qualified opportunity
- Customer needs & outcomes defined
- Stakeholders identified

- Business case validated
- Solution approach agreed
- Technical feasibility confirmed

- Proposed solution agreed
- Customer buy-in on value
- Proposal submitted

- Customer agreement in place
- Contract signed
- Kickoff readiness

- Value realized
- Customer satisfied
- Expansion opportunities identified

HCEM STAGES & ACTIVITIES

A structured, repeatable approach to win, implement and expand with customers



Customer
Success



Integrity &
Trust



Simplify &
Automate



Innovate &
Deliver Value

HCEM Stages	1 Discover Understand & Qualify	2 Diagnose Analyze & Design	3 Design Solution & Business Case	4 Close Commit & Contract	5 Adopt & Expand Deliver Value & Grow
Exit Criteria 	- Qualified opportunity - Customer needs & outcomes defined - Key stakeholders identified - Initial business case direction	- Business case validated - Current state & gaps documented - Solution approach agreed - Technical feasibility confirmed	- Proposed solution agreed - Customer buy-in on value - Proposal submitted - Implementation approach defined	- Customer agreement in place - Contract signed - Kickoff readiness confirmed - Success plan finalized	- Value realized - Customer satisfied - Expansion opportunities identified - Growth plan in place
Key Activities 	- Engage via partner / inbound / outbound - Understand business goals & challenges - Identify key stakeholders & influencers - Qualify opportunity (BANT + Pain) - Define success metrics (KPIs) - Map decision making process - Capture initial requirements - Confirm solution fit (high level)	- Conduct discovery workshops - Map as-is processes - Identify gaps and improvement areas - Define functional requirements - Assess technical environment - Estimate ROI & business impact - Identify risks and assumptions - Validate budget & timeline	- Design future state solution - Configure & demonstrate - Create architecture & integration plan - Develop implementation roadmap - Build business case & ROI - Define success plan & governance - Identify partner roles & responsibilities - Proposal & commercial model	- Finalize commercial terms - Address objections & negotiate - Legal & compliance review - Procurement process support - Obtain approvals - Contract sign-off - Kickoff & resource mobilization - Implementation planning	- Implement & onboard users - Train users & super users - Monitor adoption & usage - Measure KPI achievements - Provide ongoing support - Conduct QBRs & health checks - Identify cross-sell / up-sell - Drive continuous optimization
Verifiable Outcomes 	- Opportunity logged in CRM - Business objectives documented - Stakeholder map created - Initial KPIs defined - Qualification score achieved	- Current state documented - Gap analysis completed - Business case validated - Technical feasibility sign-off - Budget & timeline confirmed	- Solution design approved - Business case endorsed - Proposal submitted - Implementation plan approved - Success plan draft created	- Contract signed - Project kickoff completed - Implementation team aligned - Governance structure approved - Project plan baselined	- Solution live in production - KPIs improving - Customer satisfaction achieved - Expansion pipeline created - Renewal plan in place
Stage Accountability 	Partner / Sales Lead: Partner / Sales Support: Pre-sales, Marketing	Partner + Pre-sales Lead: Partner / Solution Consultant Support: Pre-sales, Product, Finance	Partner + Solution Architect Lead: Partner / Solution Architect Support: Pre-sales, Finance, Legal	Partner + Commercial Lead: Partner / Account Manager Support: Legal, Finance, Leadership	Customer Success Lead: CSM / Partner Support: Support, Product, PS

HCEM PRINCIPLES



Customer First
Understand deeply,
deliver value.



Partner Powered
Win together,
grow together.



Simplify & Automate
Reduce complexity,
increase productivity.



Trust & Transparency
Build trust through
honesty and clarity.



Deliver & Expand
Deliver results and
drive growth.

LEGEND

Engagement Stages

1 Discover 2 Diagnose 3 Design 4 Close 5 Adopt & Expand

Influence / Sentiment

● Advocate ● Neutral ● Detractor

Forecast Categories

Commit Commit At Risk Upside Uncommitted



1. Explore these areas early during Discover and continuously validate through the customer engagement.
2. If any area is weak or unclear, you may not have a qualified opportunity. Revisit, revalidate and re-qualify.

1 Identify Customer Outcomes



Outcomes: What are the high-level expected business outcomes, returns or KPIs the customer wants to achieve?

Project Importance: How do the customer's goals, strategies, business challenges and initiatives align to this opportunity?

HostBooks Scope: What are the customer's needs for ERP/Accounting/Tax/Compliance/Automation and other capabilities?

Risks: Are there known or projected risks? What's stopped this project in the past or what could stop it now?



Key Output: Clear outcomes, success metrics and scope alignment.

2 Determine Approval Process



Stakeholders: Which individuals and teams need to be involved, including decision makers and influencers?

Authority: Who has the BANT (Budget, Authority, Need, Timing) to approve and move forward?

Sponsors: Who is the executive sponsor/champion? Do they have sponsorship and support to proceed?

Governance: What is the internal approval process and timeline?



Key Output: Defined stakeholder map and approval path.

3 Validate Budget Availability



Funding: Is the budget available? Is it CapEx, OpEx or Subscription?

Problem Scope: What is the estimated investment range compared to the business value expected?

Budget Owner: Who owns and controls the budget?

Business Case: Has the budget been allocated or can it be re-allocated for this initiative?



Key Output: Budget confirmed or pathway to secure budget.

4 Confirm Timing



Timing: What is the expected decision date?

Decision Lifecycle: Where is the customer in their buying journey?

Buying Process: What are the key milestones and events leading to the decision?

Constraints: Are there dependencies (audit, compliance, board approval, fiscal year, implementation window) that impact timing?



Key Output: Clear timeline, milestones and go-live window.

Qualification Tips



Ask Open Questions
Uncover real pain points and expectations.



Listen Actively
Understand context, challenges and urgency.



Document & Share
Capture insights and align with stakeholders.



Re-qualify Continuously
Validate assumptions at each stage.



Focus on Value
Link every conversation to business outcomes.



FORECAST CATEGORIES

Select the category that best represents the probability of closing based on customer commitment, stage progress and risk assessment.



Commit
(> 95%)

Customer has approved the solution, budget and business case. Contract is in final stages.

High Confidence
Will Close



Commit At Risk
(> 75%)

Customer intends to buy but there are identifiable risks that could impact the close.

Medium-High Confidence



Upside
(> 50%)

Strong opportunity with active discussions but final approval or funding is pending.

Medium Confidence



Uncommitted
(< 50%)

Qualification incomplete or significant gaps in outcomes, budget, timing or approval process.

Low Confidence

FORECAST DRIVERS

Driver

What to Assess



Customer Commitment

Level of customer intent, verbal/written commitment and engagement.



Solution Fit

How well our solution meets the customer needs and success metrics.



Budget Confidence

Budget approved/allocated, funding source confirmed.



Decision Process

Approval path defined, key stakeholders aligned.



Timing Certainty

Expected decision date is realistic and not slipping.



Risks & Obstacles

Open risks, competitive threats and internal/external blockers.



Next Steps Progress

Key actions completed as per plan and timeline.

FORECAST REVIEW CADENCE



Weekly

- Pipeline review with account team
- Risk & action review
- Next 5 actions update



Monthly

- Forecast submission
- Stage progression review
- Executive pipeline review



Quarterly

- Business review with partners
- Growth & expansion opportunities



Annually

- Strategic business planning
- Partner performance review
- Joint growth roadmap

KEY REMINDERS



Keep the customer at the center of every decision.



Collaborate closely with partners and leverage shared strengths.



Document everything in CRM and keep the close plan updated.



Focus on value, outcomes and long-term customer success.



Escalate early, remove blockers and keep momentum.

GOVERNANCE ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

Role

Key Responsibilities



Account Owner (HostBooks)

Owns the opportunity, drives the process, maintains close plan and forecast.



Partner Lead

Leads customer engagement, manages partner team and resources.



Solution Consultant

Solutions design, demos, POC and technical validation.



Finance / Commercial Lead

Pricing, commercial structuring, contract & financial approvals.



Implementation Lead

Implementation scope, plan, resource mobilization and delivery.



Customer Success Manager

Post-go-live adoption, value realization and expansion.



Executive Sponsor

Provides executive support, escalates blockers and builds strategic alignment.

SUCCESS CHECKLIST



Customer outcomes clearly defined



Proposal & commercial reviewed



Stakeholders & approval process identified



Contract & legal in final stages



Budget availability confirmed



Implementation plan aligned



Solution & business case agreed



Go-live readiness confirmed



Risks identified & mitigation plan in place



Success metrics & value tracking plan in place



HCEM PRINCIPLES



Customer First

We start with the customer and work backwards.



Partner Powered

We win together by growing together.



Simplicity

We keep it simple to accelerate outcomes.



Integrity

We do the right thing with transparency.



Innovation

We innovate to solve real business problems.



Impact

We deliver measurable business value.